

From Blah to Boardroom:



The **Science** Behind **Exec-Ready** Presentations

About the Author



Hi there! This is Herng.

A bit about me: I am a strategist at Google (coming up on nearly a decade). Outside of work, I write a free [weekly newsletter](#) for high performers in tech.

I'd love to hear your feedback on this playbook.
Please feel free to drop me a note on [LinkedIn](#)!

Hi! I'll cut to the chase.

I build **slides** for a living.

My work tends to go in front of **senior executives**.

My slides aren't perfect – but they're always **exec-ready**.

And in this playbook, I'll teach you the **science** behind how I do it.

You should also know this about me:

It wasn't always like this.

When I started out as a junior analyst, my slides were **unserviceable**.
Well, my slides weren't bad. They just weren't **exec-ready** at all.

But over the years, I improved. By **stealing and copying**.
I took (copious amounts of) hard feedback – and internalized it.
I read good slides from other people – and just copied their formats.

Now, many years later, my slides still aren't perfect. But they're always exec-ready.
Because I simply follow a set of **foolproof principles**.

Here's my **my final (and maybe controversial) point.**

There's no art to slide-writing.

It's not an art and a science.

It's just science.

After many years of trial and error, this is what I believe:

You don't need fancy words.

You don't need an artistic sense (I certainly don't).

You don't need complicated visuals.

You don't need consulting frameworks.

You just need to **treat slide-writing as a science.**

You just need to **follow foolproof principles.**

Good slide-writing isn't easy. But it can be mastered.

Good slide-writing isn't easy.

It takes time to master.

But it will pay incredible dividends down the road.

Just know this: It isn't **rocket science**.

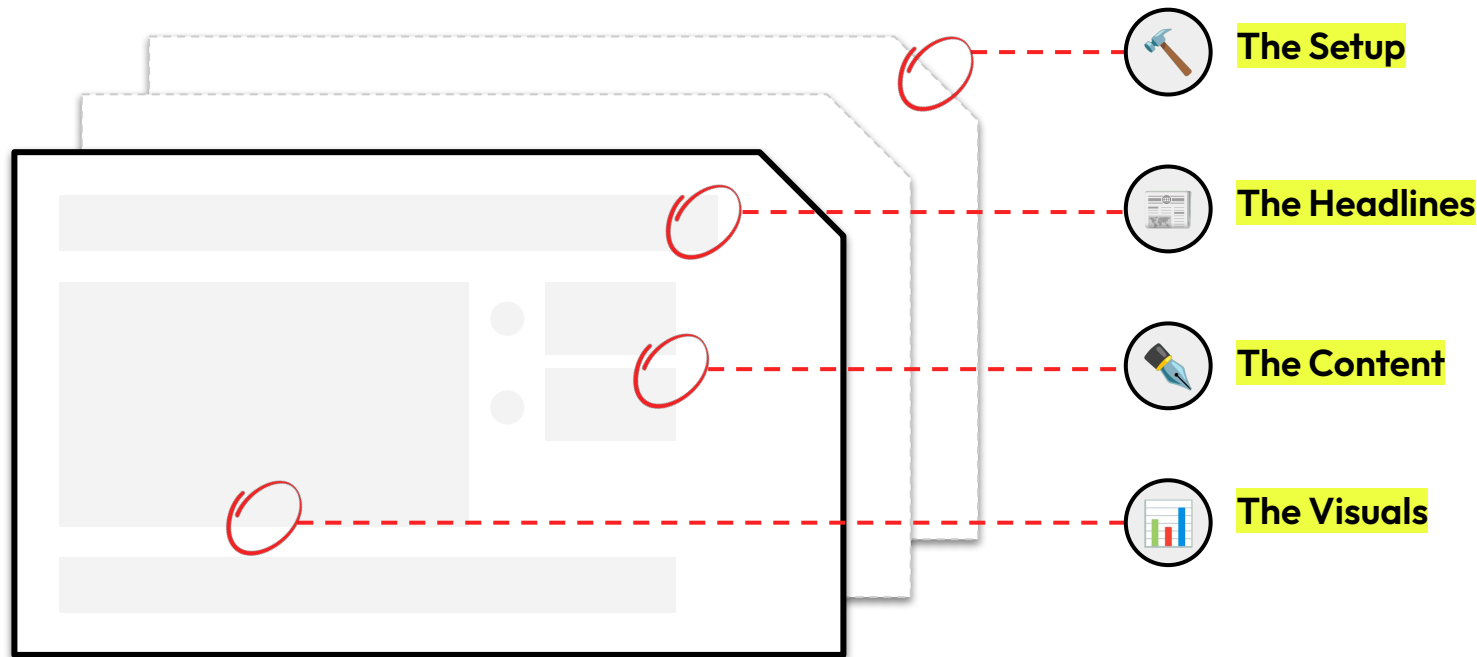
Anyone can master it.

Anyone can build boardroom-worthy slides.

You just need the right playbook.

So without further ado...

There are **4 Pillars** behind Every Exec-Ready Presentation:





4 Key Pillars. 24 Guiding Principles in Total.

START HERE



The Setup

Use the Pyramid Principle

Ordering Matters

Cut Until You Can't

Don't Use Animations

If You Get to Voiceover...

Use Appendix & Pre-Read



The Content

Always Be Selling

Avoid Complex Charts

"Grammatical" Mindset

Minimize Jargon

Make Tradeoffs

Put Things in Context



The Headlines

Write Your Headlines First

...Make Them Strong

...Make Them Direct

...and Make Them Crisp

Use the Right Tone

Commentate. Not Label



The Visuals

Be VERY Careful with Circles

Beautify Your Tables

Use Callout Boxes

Use Signposts

Avoid Generic Icons

Some Colors = 1000 Words



The Setup

Use the Pyramid Principle. Always.

Most presentations are built with very logical storylines — this is not a bad thing at all. After all, presentations are stories, and so the storytelling logic has to make sense.

So they start with the data they looked at, the insights they uncovered, and the conclusion they arrived at.

Don't do this. Instead, use **Barbara Minto's Pyramid Principle:**

- Lead with the answer / conclusion first
- Give a high-level view of the supporting arguments
- Surface the data and facts that back up these claims

As Minto put it: "You think from the bottom up, but you present from the top down."

Use the **Pyramid Principle**. Always.



I see a broken
spotlight falling
from the sky

I see a column of
rain that only
follows me



I may be in "The Truman Show"



I need to GTFO ASAP



I need your help to escape. Here's why.



I may be in "The Truman Show..."



I see a broken
spotlight falling
from the sky...

I see a column of
rain that only
follows me...

Be incredibly intentional about the order of things.

I often see near-perfect presentations make this critical mistake:

Neglecting to list things in the order of importance, urgency, or impact.

Whether it's a table or a list of bullet points – **the order matters.**

Everything you do (or don't do) carries implications.

The first item in a list inevitably carries higher importance.

Even if you didn't intend for it to.

(And if you have to jump in and clarify that item #3 is actually the most important item:

Well, you just look **unprofessional and unprepared.**)

Be incredibly intentional about the order of things.



Exec Support is Required to Launch Project Armadillo

- Agreement to a monthly review forum among key executives
- Repurpose 30% of marketing budget from Project Sunshine
- Conduct in-depth user study by Q2

PROBABLY THE MOST IMPORTANT ITEM. SHOULD GO FIRST.



Exec Support is Required to Launch Project Armadillo

- **Repurpose 30% of marketing budget from Project Sunshine**
- Conduct in-depth user study by Q2
- Agreement to a monthly review forum among key executives

Cut down on your slides (until you can't anymore)

More isn't always better when it comes to presentations.

If you have any slides that are ineffective or redundant – that's a red flag.

You want to make sure that **every slide has a distinct purpose.**

So look at every one of your slides, and **ask yourself:**

“If I removed a certain slide, does your story flow break?”

“Is my argument significantly weakened?”

If the answer is “not really,” you have a **lazy slide** that needs to work harder or get scrapped.

To have any slides that don't “work” hard enough to deliver impact is to **waste the valuable time** you have with exec-level audiences.

The opportunity cost is larger than you think.

Don't use animations.

Don't use animations. Here's why.

When you're in front of execs, you won't get to control **the flow**.
They will interject with comments and questions as they please.

And when they throw questions at you, you want to tackle those questions directly.
Or jump quickly to the relevant slide.

But if you happen to be in the middle of your cool, multi-click animation flow:
You'll end up **frantically** clicking around, trying to find the right landing spot.

Exception: When you are in full control of the flow, and no one will interrupt you.
E.g. a townhall meeting where you're **presenting unilaterally**.

If you'll get to **voiceover**: cut down on text. But if not...

If you know for sure you'll get to **voiceover** (or at least control the flow):

Then you have permission to use simple bullet points and minimal text.

But if you're not sure (or if you know your deck will circulate without you):

Make sure that your deck is comprehensible on a **standalone basis**.

This doesn't mean dumping **a mountain of text** on every slide.

But it does mean a tad more bias towards **self-enclosed phrases or sentences**.

Because here's the thing – **things won't always go as planned**. For instance:

- Some execs are impatient and might interrupt you, instead of letting you dictate the flow
- They might show up late (thus leaving you with less time than planned)
- They might change the agenda last-minute
- The meeting might even get cancelled, and you'll have to send your materials offline

If you expect these curveballs: bias towards making your materials as standalone as possible.

If you'll get to **voiceover**: cut down on text. But if not...



Good Will Hunting provides timeless lessons on human relationships

- "How do you like them apples?"
- "I gotta see about a girl."
- "It's not your fault."

THIS IS NOT WRONG – BUT IT'S AN INTENTIONAL SETUP THAT ONLY WORKS IF YOU'LL GET TO VOICEOVER AND CONTROL THE FLOW.

WHEN IT WORKS WELL, IT WORKS REALLY WELL.



Good Will Hunting provides timeless lessons on human relationships

- Big difference between book-smart and street-smart
- Fortune favors the bold. Take risks if you have to.
- Childhood trauma can haunt us for a long time

NOT AS CLEAN, AND NOT AS MUCH INTRIGUE. BUT IT CAN SERVE VERY SPECIFIC PURPOSES.

Use the **Appendix** and **Pre-Read** to your advantage.

You don't need to cover everything in a live presentation.

Example #1:

Have a financial model that supports your argument?

Don't waste precious discussion time talking through each of your variables.

Keep it in the appendix to establish credibility. And just call out key assumptions live.

Example #2:

Does your presentation require the audience to understand market nuances?

Put in a couple pre-read slides (and tell people to scan through prior to the meeting).

You'll get to focus on more hard-hitting messages during your live meeting.



The Content

Always be selling. Otherwise you're doing it wrong.

On every slide, you should be **selling** the audience something:

- It can be an ask for resources.
- It can be a narrative intended to bust some myths.
- It can be to lay the groundwork for a future pitch.

Whatever it is, you always want a **call-to-action**.

Even if it's not explicit.

I'm not saying that you can't have slides dedicated to **pure updates or education**.

But it should be minimal. Everything else should have a clear **"so what."**

Put differently: You're presenting to executives because you want to **influence them**.

So you need to ask yourself: "What do I want from these execs as a result?"

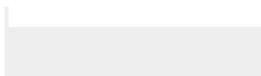
(And if there's no call-to-action, you better make sure it's a damn insightful update.)

Always be selling. Otherwise you're doing it wrong.

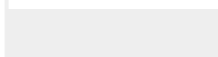


We delivered xx% sales growth this year

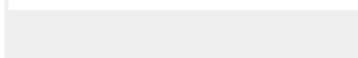
Market A:



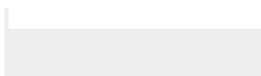
Market B:



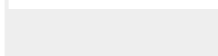
Market C:



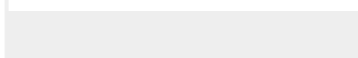
Product X:



Product Y:



Product Z:



MISSED OPPORTUNITY FOR DEEPER INSIGHT AND CALL-TO-ACTION. NOT WORTHY OF EXEC TIME.



We delivered xx% sales growth this year
with best-in-class efficiency



AT A GLANCE, THERE'S NO CALL TO ACTION – BUT THE “EFFICIENCY” MESSAGE ENHANCES THE PERCEPTION OF THE BUSINESS, AND CAN ENABLE FUTURE ASKS...

Avoid complex charts. Most people won't get it.

When it comes to graphs & charts, I believe in 2 things:

- Learn how to interpret complex charts – so no one can hoodwink you.
- Then forget about them and avoid using them unless necessary.

The truth is that most people get overwhelmed by anything more than a 2 by 2 matrix.

Sure, complex charts are valuable and useful.

But you need to know your audience. Most of the time, it just creates confusion.

See the next page for some guidance on what charts to use (and which to avoid).

Avoid complex charts. Most people won't get it.

Use Confidently

Bar Charts



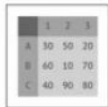
Bubble Chart



Waterfall



Table Charts



Scatterplot



Line Chart



Use with Caution

Treemap



Stacked Area



Pie Chart*



Candlestick



Venn Diagram



Heatmap



Try to Avoid

Radar



Bump Area



Nightingale



Sankey



Dot Plot



* Not b/c it's hard, but b/c likely to mislead. See [here](#).

Be “grammatical” if you can.

The hidden danger with slides is that it's easy to get away with **lazy thinking**.
Unlike writing prose in a document – you're not forced to articulate with nuance.

Imagine a pretty box on a strategy slide that says **“operational rigor.”**
Who's driving the operational rigour? How is it measured?
Are we trying to do more or the same? How will we enforce it?

Sure, no one's expecting you to write a full essay. But you should have a clear story in your head.

“Grammatical” thinking means being **hyper-aware** of what you're trying to assert:
It sounds ridiculously basic, but just ask yourself: **WHO's doing WHAT (and WHY and HOW)?**

You don't have to spell out everything. That's not the point.
But you need extreme clarity in your head. All the time.

Be “grammatical” if you can.



We'll grow 2023 via 3 critical levers

- Operational Rigor
- Deepen Partner Relationships
- Collaboration



THIS ISN'T WRONG.

IT'S JUST VERY FLUFFY AND UNINSIGHTFUL.



We'll grow 2023 via 3 critical levers

- **Tighter Operational Rigor**
...via unified metrics & monthly exec forums
- **Deeper Partner Relationships**
...via revised incentives & frontline trainings
- **Better Collaboration with XYZ**
...via 3 Joint OKRs & exec governance

IN REALITY, YOU DON'T NEED TO SPELL ALL OF THIS OUT. BUT DO IT IN YOUR HEAD. SPELL OUT WHO'S DOING WHAT (AND HOW AND WHY).

IF YOU CAN'T – THEN YOU DON'T REALLY KNOW WHAT YOU'RE WRITING ABOUT.

Minimize jargon. Use simple, direct, and clear verbiage.

You don't have to avoid jargon or org-specific acronyms completely.
But you do want to minimize the risk of **confusion / conflation**.

You see, exec-ready presentations are designed to be comprehensible to execs.
Execs do not spend time in the weeds, and thus have limited context.

Challenge yourself to write using **simple, direct, and clear language**.
You then minimize the chances of of misinterpretation or distractions.

Make Tradeoffs. Don't include stuff just b/c you can.

Including too much stuff is not helpful – **it's harmful. And distracting.**

But people do it all the time, **for several reasons:**

- Everything seems important
- If I don't add more context to this bullet point, it might get misinterpreted
- Talking about work by A and B and not C seems unfair to C, so I'll include it

The key to writing exec-level presentations is **knowing what to omit.**

It's about being comfortable with **tradeoffs.**

If you **simply incorporate everything** everyone wants – you add very little value.
(And you dilute the importance of the stuff that actually matters!)

So – be comfortable with making judgment calls and leaving out stuff. Be comfortable prioritizing.
And whatever content you do choose to keep will then get its deserved **attention and spotlight.**

Make Tradeoffs. Don't include stuff just b/c you can.



Forrest Gump became who he was due to several life-changing moments

- Running skills led him to a football scholarship and meeting JFK
- Travels the world due to extraordinary Ping Pong talent
- Fulfills his promise to Bubba and finds success in his Shrimping Company
- Runs across the country and becomes a celebrity
- Reunites with Jenny and finds that he has a son



Forrest Gump became who he was due to several life-changing moments

- Enlisting for Vietnam led to friendship with Bubba and Lieutenant Dan, which resulted in good business fortunes
- Unwavering loyalty to Jenny led to fatherhood and finding fulfillment in life

FOCUS ON WHAT REALLY MATTERS.

JUST BECAUSE SOMETHING'S INTERESTING OR IMPORTANT DOESN'T MEAN YOU NEED TO INCLUDE IT.

THEN WHATEVER YOU ACTUALLY INCLUDE IS GOLDEN.

Want people to care? **Contextualize.**

Presentations don't always land well despite being backed by strong evidence. Sometimes the reason is simple: **the data isn't put into context.**

Messages are very easy to land when numbers are either big or tied to common knowledge bases.

- He makes a million dollars a year – that's a lot.
- We doubled our market share to 40% this year – that's quite impressive.
- Country X saw one million new internet users come online last year – hold up, I don't really know how to feel. Is that a lot or a little? Well, probably depends on if you're talking about Japan or Jamaica.

Want people to care? Contextualize.



"Asia has added 1.5 billion new internet users over the last decade."



Asia has added 1.5 billion new internet users over the last decade.

...that's the same as all internet users in Europe and the Americas today.



The Headlines

Write your **headlines** first.

Headlines will make or break your presentation.

They take 10 seconds to write but can take hours to get right.

Here are two questions I use to interrogate every slide in every presentation I build:

1. If I deleted everything except the headlines, do they still tell a coherent, logical, and tight-knit story?
2. Do the charts and bullet points in the slide actually support the headlines?

If I find myself answering “no” at any point, I know that I have work to do.

Write your **headlines** first (cont.)

Now, let's assume that your headlines jive with your content.
And let's assume your headlines tell a logical story.

Then, you need to pressure-test how good those headlines are individually.

Luckily enough, the guiding principles for good headlines are rather simple:

1. **Be strong**
2. **Be direct**
3. **Be crisp**

We'll talk through examples for each of these.

Write **Strong** Headlines.

Write **action-led headlines**. Or **assertive statements** if you can.

Here's a (real-life) example of a **weak headline**:

“...the project was enabled by collaboration and deep alignment.”

The issue with this headline is that it is not only **passive**, but also **uninsightful**.

Who would ever argue that collaboration isn't important for any project?

And why would you ever need to dedicate a slide to claim that it is?

The following are a **couple more examples** I've seen from actual strategy presentations that unfortunately epitomize the meaning of weak headlines:

Write **Strong** Headlines (Some Counterexamples...)



Our Focus Will Be Centered on Our Org's Themes.



WHO WOULD CLAIM THAT THEIR STRATEGY DOESN'T ALIGN TO THEIR ORG'S FOCUS AREAS? THIS HEADLINE SAYS NOTHING OF IMPORTANCE.

IF ANYTHING, IT'D BE MORE INTERESTING TO READ A HEADLINE THAT SAYS "WE'RE FOCUSING ON SOMETHING VERY DIFFERENT FROM OTHER TEAMS."



Momentum of Supplier Outreach in XYZ Country Drives Results.



WHY NOT JUST SAY: "THE SUPPLIER OUTREACH PROGRAM DROVE RESULTS?"

I ALSO DON'T KNOW WHETHER WE THINK THE RESULTS ARE VERY GOOD (OR JUST NON-ZERO).

THERE'S ALSO NO ACTIONABLE RECOMMENDATION OR IMPLIED INSIGHT. SHOULD WE DOUBLE DOWN ON THIS STRATEGY OR...?

Write **Direct** Headlines.

A lot of people think that they need **fancy words and complex sentences**. They do so to sound professional, and to be taken seriously.

This is not necessarily wrong.

There's a particular **tone and syntax** we associate with high-quality work. But this will backfire if you apply that notion to headlines.

You see, the best thing to do with headlines is this:

Be extremely simple and direct.

Avoid corporate jargon like it's the plague.

When you don't use direct, simple language: you create **distractions** for your audience.

At best they grimace and try to decode what you're actually trying to say.

At worse they simply tune it out as they assume it's generic corp-speak with little substance.

Write **Direct** Headlines (Some Counterexamples...)



Office location decisions to adapt to 3 key design objectives, leveraging a 5 question framework to define suitability.



I HAD TO READ THIS THREE TIMES.

THEN I REALIZED IT WAS SIMPLY TELLING ME THAT THERE'S A VERY SMART FRAMEWORK IN PLACE AND I SHOULD JUST TRUST IT.



Decision will be made at an agreed-upon (RACI) level by following a robust process and partner teams need to be consulted



I HAD TO READ THIS FIVE TIMES. THEN I REALIZED THE AUTHOR WAS TRYING TO SAY:

"DON'T WORRY, WE'LL HAVE CLEAR DECISION PRINCIPLES AND YOU'LL BE CONSULTED."

THIS SLIDE WAS SUPPOSED TO INSTILL CONFIDENCE. INSTEAD, I'M INCREDIBLY STRESSED OUT BY THE HEADLINE'S COMPLEXITY.

Write **Direct** Headlines (Another Example):



Large headroom ahead buoyed by market growth but our budget share is under-indexed thus requiring a fundamental pivot in go-to-market strategy



The opportunity is huge and we're missing out.

Write **Crisp** Headlines.

Caveat: this guiding principle borders slightly on style. But I truly believe it is the foolproof approach to craft an **exec-ready tone**.

? **Short, not necessarily crisp:** Our DAUs have been trending down for 3 quarters.

✓ **Short AND crisp:** We're losing users.

Another example:

? **Short, not necessarily crisp:** Competitors X & Y combined for 70% of market share.

✓ **Short AND crisp:** Market is dominated by X & Y.

In a way, the crispness comes from **elevating statements to stories**.
It gives life to (boring) factual statements.

Use the right tone. This separates the pros from amateurs.

Depending on the tone – the same slide can surface **drastically different messages**.

There's no right or wrong tone – but there is a **most suitable tone**.

And that will depend on what you want to achieve.

For example, consider the following two statements:

1. We see incredible revenue opportunity ahead of us, and have a clear roadmap to capture it
2. Exciting revenue opportunity ahead, although landing our strategy hinges on product enablement

See the difference? These could be headlines for the exact same slide, **except that:**

- The first one paints a very optimistic picture (and focuses on generating confidence)
- The second one is cautiously optimistic, and explicitly calls out dependencies to manage expectations

There's no right or wrong. **It's just nuance.**

But be very intentional about the message you want to send.

And then decide **what tone will get you there.**

Don't just label when you can also **commentate.**

Everything you put on a slide is **precious real estate.**

Everything should serve a distinct purpose.

Labeling is simply stating what something is (e.g. “2023 sales growth by market”)

Commentating reveals insight (e.g. “All our markets exceeded expectations this year”)

Labeling isn't wrong. All charts and graphs should have proper labels (and legends).

But when there are opportunities (**e.g. headers, captions**) to commentate instead of label – take advantage of it.

Don't just label when you can also **commentate.**



The Highest-Rated *Friends* Episodes, According to IMDB Users

- The One Where Everyone Finds Out
- The Last One
- The One with the Embryos
- The One with the Prom Video
- The One with the Rumor

NEVER MISTAKE LABELS FOR HEADLINES. THEY'RE NOT INSIGHTFUL AND WEAK.



The Best Episodes of *Friends* Aren't Just Funny – They're Also Sentimental

Top 5 *Friends* Episodes, according to IMDB

- The One Where Everyone Finds Out
- The Last One
- The One with the Embryos
- The One with the Prom Video
- The One with the Rumor

MUCH BETTER. MUCH MORE INTERESTING.



The Visuals

Be VERY careful with **circles**.

Avoid pie charts. And be very careful with **concentric circles**.

Here's why: Humans are just bad at interpreting things like **pie slices** or **circular areas**.

Take pie charts as an example:

The relative sizes of pie slices are just very hard to conceptualize.

A slice that is 2x the size of another will somehow come out looking much bigger.

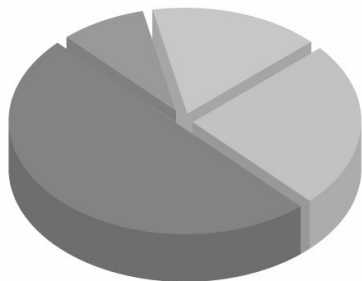
Concentric circles are similar.

While it makes perfect sense to show relative market sizes using a small circle within a bigger one:

It is difficult for most people to **accurately grasp the ratio**. You're better off **using rectangles**.

So, just keep it simple. Minimize the potential risk of misinterpretation. Use bar charts.

Be VERY careful with circles.



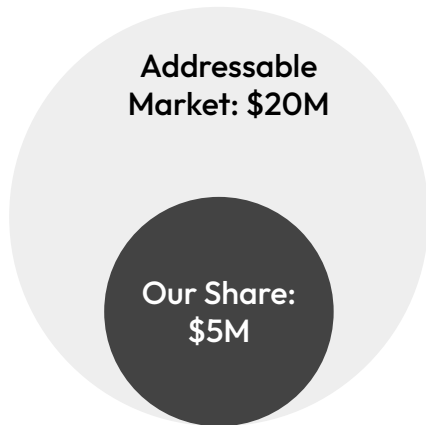
DON'T USE PIE CHARTS. IT JUST LEADS TO MISLEADING INTERPRETATIONS.

OH, AND FOR GOD'S SAKE – DEFINITELY DON'T USE 3D PIE CHARTS. IT MAKE THINGS WORSE.



THERE'S NO REASON WHY YOU CAN'T USE A SIMPLE BAR CHART TO CONVEY THE SAME MESSAGE CLEARLY AND UNEQUIVOCALLY.

Be VERY careful with circles.



WE ONLY HAVE 25% OF THE MARKET: BUT FEELS MUCH BIGGER DUE TO THE VISUAL.

UNLESS YOUR GOAL IS TO MISLEAD INTENTIONALLY: OTHERWISE DON'T USE CONCENTRIC CIRCLES.



100% CLEAR. NO RISK OF MISINTERPRETATION.



Don't let **ugly tables** cheapen your awesome work.

Tables are simple. There's no way to mess them up, right?

It turns out that **tables are ugly by default**. But you need to use them. So if you don't beautify them – the rest of your slide will suffer.

Yes, this has nothing to do with content or material. It's simply **aesthetics**.

But you invested so much effort into building your content already. Why not use clean-looking tables to minimize **distractions**?

Don't let ugly tables cheapen your awesome work.



THERE'S NOTHING "WRONG" WITH THESE TABLES...

	A	B	C
Revenue	\$300	\$450	\$88
Costs	\$200	\$400	\$77
Total	\$100	\$50	\$11

	A	B
Clicks	#	#
Views	#	#
Likes	#	#

BUT: THEY'RE NOT "NICE."
WHICH MEANS UNNECESSARY DISTRACTIONS.



Widgets Sold by Markets

Argentina	100
Brazil	300
Chile	250
Peru	450
Ecuador	75
Total	1175

MINIMALIST TABLES
TEND TO WORK WELL.

REDUCE DISTRACTIONS
AS MUCH AS YOU CAN.

FAMILY	STAFF	FUNDS	COSTS	RISKS
Corleone Lorem ipsum	#	\$	\$	XX
Tattaglia Lorem ipsum	#	\$	\$	XX
Barzini Lorem ipsum	#	\$	\$	XX
Cuneo Lorem ipsum	#	\$	\$	XX

Use callout boxes. Help your audience follow along.

Have a chart or table that contains **multiple messages?**

Just use callout boxes & labels, and keep everything on one slide.

You'll get to keep your overall presentation **tight**.

And you'll ensure that **the linkage** between the messages isn't lost.

Alternative is to use pseudo-animations, i.e. creating multiple slides with the same chart, with each having a different section highlighted.

Sometimes this works. But it also depends on if you're presenting live and whether you get to [control the flow](#). Much easier to make it foolproof by keeping it to one slide.

Use callout boxes. Help your audience follow along.



FAMILY	STAFF	FUNDS	COSTS	RISKS
Corleone Lorem ipsum	#	\$	\$	XX
Tattaglia Lorem ipsum	#	\$	\$	XX
Barzini Lorem ipsum	#	\$	\$	XX
Cuneo Lorem ipsum	#	\$	\$	XX

- Corleone family has insufficient funds
- Tattaglia's costs are out of control
- Barzini is facing unprecedented risks



FAMILY	STAFF	FUNDS	COSTS	RISKS
Corleone Lorem ipsum	#	\$	\$	XX
Tattaglia Lorem ipsum	#	\$	\$	XX
Barzini Lorem ipsum	#	\$	\$	XX
Cuneo Lorem ipsum	#	\$	\$	XX

- 1 Corleone family has insufficient funds
- 2 Tattaglia's costs are out of control
- 3 Barzini is facing unprecedented risks

Use signposts. Help your audience follow along.

A long presentation that has multiple sections (and sub-sections) isn't bad. But it can be very difficult for the audience to follow along, especially live.

If the audience doesn't know if they're in the first 10% or last 30% of the narrative: That creates **confusion**. Which creates **distractions**.

Thankfully, you can solve this easily with **signposting**.

Think of it as a progress bar.

Your audience will then have a clear mental map of where you are.

Use signposts. Help your audience follow along.



1-1	1-2	1-3
2-1	2-2	3-1
3-2	3-3	3-4
3-5	4-1	4-2

LENGTHY PRESENTATION WITH NO INDICATION OF WHICH SECTION / SUB-SECTION YOU'RE IN



Strategy
Overview

Market
Deep-Dive

Resourcing
Asks

USE SIMPLE SIGNPOSTS ON THE TOP RIGHT CORNER TO HELP YOUR AUDIENCE FOLLOW ALONG

Avoid **Generic Icons.** They Cheapen Everything.

Nice icons can be the icing on the cake of a great slide.

Generic icons **cheapen everything** in your slide.

What's a generic icon? I can't describe it, but I know it when I see it.

- I consider these **generic icons**:



- While these are **slightly better**:



(source)

- Emojis** can also work well, with a bit of packaging:



- In general: if you've seen it before, it's probably a generic icon.

Avoid **Generic Icons.** They Cheapen Everything.



Here are my favorite Agatha Christie Novels:



Murder on the Orient Express



The Murder of Roger Ackroyd



Witness for the Prosecution



Death on the Nile



And Then There Were None

THESE ICONS AREN'T BAD. THEY JUST FEEL CHEAP.



My favorite Agatha Christie Novels all involve completely unexpected twists:



Murder on the Orient Express



The Murder of Roger Ackroyd



Witness for the Prosecution



Death on the Nile



And Then There Were None

YOU DON'T NEED PROPRIETARY ICONS.
USE EMOJIS. IT JUST FEELS NICER.

Sometimes, **a color** is worth a thousand words.

Whatever color scheme you use is fine.

But be careful with **Green**, **Yellow** / **Orange**, **Red**.

These colors tend to suggest **universally accepted connotations**.

- **Green** = upside, growth, good progress, achievements, etc.
- **Yellow** / **Orange** = work-in-progress, tentativeness, uncertainty, not good enough, etc.
- **Red** = risk, inadequate, warning, danger, gap, etc.

So use them intentionally – they can add useful context to your slides.

But the opposite is true: if you use them inconsistently, they can mislead or confuse.

Sometimes, **a color** is worth a thousand words.



We delivered some big wins in 2023, although there were misses as well

- We signed **the biggest deal** in 3 years
- Customer satisfaction **improved**
- We hit **6 out of 10 OKRs**
- We saw **limited customer churn** despite facing staffing challenges

CONFUSING COLORING. SOME EVEN CONTRADICT THE INTENDED MESSAGE.



We delivered some big wins in 2023, although there were misses as well

- We signed **the biggest deal** in 3 years
- We **minimized customer churn** despite facing staffing challenges
- CSAT **improved by 5pts (goal = +10pt)**
- We hit **6 out of 10 OKRs**

MUCH LESS CONFUSING, AND MUCH EASIER TO UNDERSTAND THE INTENDED SENTIMENT BEHIND THE BULLET POINTS.



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